

**Nathaniel Posner**

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**EDUCATION**


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|---------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------|
| Ph.D.   | Columbia Business School, Columbia University, Marketing                      | 2027 (expected) |
| M.Phil. | Columbia Business School, Columbia University, Marketing                      | 2025            |
| B.A.    | Vassar College ( <i>with honors</i> ), Major: Psychology;<br>Minor: Economics | 2019            |

**AWARDS AND HONORS**


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2026 AMA-Sheth Doctoral Consortium Fellow  
2024 AMA-EBSCO-RRBM Responsible Research in Marketing Award  
2024 Luxury Education Foundation Award  
2019 Phi Beta Kappa

**PUBLICATIONS**


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Posner, Nathaniel, Andrey Simonov, Kellen Mrkva, and Eric J. Johnson (2023), “Dark Defaults: Choice Architecture Steers Political Campaign Donations,” *Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences*, 120(40), e2218385120.

- Winner of 2024 AMA-EBSCO-RRBM award.
- Covered in NPR’s The Indicator from Planet Money, Morning Edition.

Reeck, Crystal, Nathaniel Posner, Kellen Mrkva, and Eric J. Johnson (2023), “Nudging App Adoption: Choice Architecture Facilitates Consumer Uptake of Mobile Apps,” *Journal of Marketing*, 87(4), 510-527.

Mrkva, Kellen, Nathaniel Posner, Crystal Reeck, and Eric J. Johnson (2021), “Do Nudges Reduce Disparities? Choice Architecture Compensates for Low Consumer Knowledge,” *Journal of Marketing*, 85(4), 67-84.

- Finalist for the 2023 AMA-EBSCO-RRBM award.
- Honorable Mention for the 2022 BSPA Best Paper Award.

**MANUSCRIPTS IN REVIEW PROCESS**


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Posner, Nathaniel, and Joe Gladstone, “Beyond Exponential Growth Bias: Principal Linearity Neglect in Savings Judgments,” under second-round review at *Journal of Consumer Psychology*.

Posner, Nathaniel, Eric S. Park, and Bernd Schmitt, “Linguistic Variability, Mind Perception, and Trust in Artificial Intelligence,” revising for second-round review at *Journal of Marketing*.

Posner, Nathaniel, and Vicki Morwitz, “Social Concerns and Financial Reasoning when Borrowing from Family,” revising for resubmission to *Journal of Consumer Research* (Dissertation essay 1; Job Market Paper).

## WORKING PAPERS

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Posner, Nathaniel, Elizabeth Friedman, and Jason Dana, “Silent Sanctions: Costly Private Welfare Destruction in Response to Innocuous Yet Repugnant Consumption Behaviors,” manuscript in preparation (intended submission to *Journal of Consumer Research*).

Posner, Nathaniel, Shai Davidai, and Vicki Morwitz, “Misperceptions of Indebtedness Promote Prosociality,” working paper (intended submission to *Journal of Personality and Social Psychology*).

Posner, Nathaniel, and Vicki Morwitz, “The Marketization of Informal Help,” manuscript in preparation (Dissertation essay 2; intended submission to *Journal of Consumer Research*).

## RESEARCH IN PROGRESS

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Posner, Nathaniel, Antonia Krefeld-Schwalb, and Bram Van den Bergh, “A Theory of Consolation Prizes.”

Posner, Nathaniel, and Joe Gladstone, “The Relationship Between Optimism and Debt.”

Posner, Nathaniel, and Maayan Malter, “Quantification in Interpersonal Interaction.”

Lee, Joseph, Nathaniel Posner, and Vicki Morwitz, “The Impact of Risky Financial Decision-Making on Social Judgment.”

## OTHER PUBLICATIONS

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Reeck, Crystal, Nathaniel Posner, Kellen Mrkva, and Eric J. Johnson (2025), “Bringing Digital Designs to Light,” *California Management Review*.

Mrkva, Kellen, Eric J. Johnson, Crystal Reeck, and Nathaniel Posner (2021), “Design Systems with Your Most Vulnerable Users in Mind,” *Harvard Business Review*.

## RESEARCH INTERESTS

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The psychology of money and debt, social interaction in the marketplace, informal and formal exchange, choice architecture, financial decision-making

## GRANTS

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2025 Columbia Business School. Bernstein Center Leadership Grant

2025 Columbia Business School. Doctoral Fellowship

2024 Columbia Experimental Laboratory for Social Sciences Dissertation Grant

2024 AMA-EBSCO-RRBM Responsible Research in Marketing Grant

2024 Columbia Business School Marketing Department Research Grant

2024 Columbia Experimental Laboratory for Social Sciences Seed Grant

2018 Vassar College Undergraduate Research Award

## INVITED TALKS

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|                                                                |      |
|----------------------------------------------------------------|------|
| Temple University, Philadelphia, PA (upcoming)                 | 2026 |
| Erasmus University Rotterdam, Rotterdam, Netherlands           | 2024 |
| American Marketing Association Academic Conference, Boston, MA | 2024 |

## CHAIRED SPECIAL SESSIONS

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Posner, Nathaniel, Antonia Krefeld-Schwalb, and Bram Van den Bergh, “Dimensions of Remuneration: How Payment Affects Consumer Behavior,” ACR, October 2025.

Posner, Nathaniel, and Vicki Morwitz, “Borrowing, Repayment, and Indebtedness: Consumer Borrowing Behavior in Formal and Informal Contexts,” ACR, October 2025.

## CONFERENCE PRESENTATIONS (\*PRESENTING AUTHOR)

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Posner, Nathaniel\*, Elizabeth Friedman, and Jason Dana “Silent Sanctions,” BDRM Conference, Flash Talk, June 2026 (upcoming).

Posner, Nathaniel\*, and Vicki Morwitz, “Help-Seeking in the Marketplace,” BSPA Conference, Talk, June 2026 (upcoming).

Posner, Nathaniel\*, and Vicki Morwitz, “Help-Seeking in the Marketplace,” SPSP JDM Preconference, Poster, February 2026.

Posner, Nathaniel\*, Antonia Krefeld-Schwalb, and Bram Van den Bergh, “The Impact of Rewards on Past and Future Effort,” ACR, Talk presented as part of a special session, October 2025.

Posner, Nathaniel\*, and Vicki Morwitz, “When Do We Ask? A Norms-Based Account of Consumer Informal Borrowing,” ACR, Talk presented as part of a special session, October 2025.

Posner, Nathaniel\*, and Vicki Morwitz, “Psychological Interest Rates,” Colorado Conference on Consumer Financial Decision Making, Poster, May 2025.

Posner, Nathaniel, Eric S. Park\*, and Bernd Schmitt, “When Consumers Credit AI with Consciousness,” SCP, Competitive Paper, March 2025.

Posner, Nathaniel\*, Antonia Krefeld-Schwalb, and Bram Van den Bergh, “Psychological Impacts of Receiving ‘Free’ Money,” SJDM, Poster, November 2024.

Posner, Nathaniel\*, and Shai Davidai, “Misperceptions of Indebtedness Promote Prosociality,” ACR, Competitive Paper, September 2024.

Posner, Nathaniel\*, Eric S. Park, and Bernd Schmitt, “When Consumers Credit AI with Consciousness,” ACR, Talk presented as part of a special session, September 2024.

Posner, Nathaniel\*, and Shai Davidai, “Who Pays the Bill? Misperceptions of Indebtedness in Joint Consumption,” SCP, Competitive Paper, March 2024.

Posner, Nathaniel\*, and Vicki Morwitz, “From Friends to Firms: Dissecting Consumer Reactions to Time and Money Requests Across Diverse Relationships,” ACR, Poster, October 2023.

Posner, Nathaniel\*, Andrey Simonov, Kellen Mrkva, and Eric J. Johnson, “Dark Defaults: How Choice Architecture Steers Campaign Donations,” ACR, Talk presented as part of a special session, October 2022.

Reeck, Crystal\*, Nathaniel Posner, Kellen Mrkva, and Eric J. Johnson, “Nudging App Adoption: Choice Architecture Increases Adoption of COVID-19 Digital Contact Tracing,” ACR, Talk presented virtually, October 2021.

Reeck, Crystal\*, Nathaniel Posner, Kellen Mrkva, and Eric J. Johnson, “Choice Architecture Facilitates Adoption of COVID-19 Digital Contact Tracing,” Conference on Behavioral Economics Experiments and Insights on COVID-19, Talk presented virtually, 2021.

Mrkva, Kellen\*, Nathaniel Posner, Crystal Reeck, and Eric J. Johnson, “Do Nudges Reduce Disparities? Choice Architecture Compensates for Low Knowledge and SES,” SJDM, Talk presented virtually, December 2020.

#### SERVICE TO THE FIELD

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*European Journal of Social Psychology*, ad hoc reviewer, 2025.

*Journal of Consumer Research*, trainee reviewer, 2025.

*Society for Consumer Psychology Conference*, ad hoc reviewer, 2024, 2025, 2026.

#### SERVICE TO THE SCHOOL

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Coordinator, Behavioral Research Lab Meeting (“Behavioral Show and Tell”), Fall 2025 and Spring 2026

#### TEACHING INTERESTS

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Marketing core, Marketing with AI, Marketing analytics, Digital marketing, Data science in marketing, Marketing strategy, Consumer behavior, Research methods, Behavioral economics, Consumer finance

## TEACHING EXPERIENCE: SERVED AS TEACHING ASSISTANT

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### MBA Courses

|                                              |           |                                 |
|----------------------------------------------|-----------|---------------------------------|
| Marketing Analytics                          | 2025      | Hortense Fong, Malek Ben Sliman |
| Behavioral Economics and Decision Making     | 2025      | Eric J. Johnson                 |
| Data Science for Marketing Managers          | 2024      | Shawndra Hill                   |
| Marketing Core                               | 2023-2025 | Andrey Simonov, Ran Kivetz      |
| Psychology and Economics of Consumer Finance | 2022      | Eric Johnson and Stephen Zeldes |

### Executive MBA Courses

|                            |           |            |
|----------------------------|-----------|------------|
| High-Tech Entrepreneurship | 2023-2024 | Ran Kivetz |
| Marketing Strategy         | 2022-2023 | Ran Kivetz |

### Ph.D. and Undergraduate Courses

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|------------------------------------------|------|----------------|
| Experimental Design and Research Methods | 2024 | Michel Pham    |
| Marketing Management                     | 2023 | Andrey Simonov |

SELECTED COURSEWORK

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## Consumer Behavior

Consumer Behavior I  
Consumer Behavior II  
Bridging Behavioral Economics and Marketing  
Science

Michel Pham, Bernd Schmitt  
Eric J. Johnson  
Ran Kivetz

## Quantitative Marketing and Economics

Empirical Models in Marketing  
Marketing, Decisions and Methods  
Economic Analysis I & II

Oded Netzer  
Donald Lehmann  
Geoffrey Heal

## Methodology

Research Methods I (Experimental Methods)  
Research Methods II (Econometric Methods)  
Natural Language Processing  
Applied Multivariate Statistics  
Experimental Design

Gita Johar  
Bo Cowgill  
Patrick Houlihan  
Kamel Jedidi  
Michel Pham

## Psychology

Theories in Social and Personality Psychology  
Cognitive Processes  
Decision Architecture  
Political Psychology (NYU)

E. Tory Higgins  
Janet Metcalfe  
Katherine Fox-Glassman  
John Jost

## REFERENCES

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Professor Vicki G. Morwitz  
Bruce Greenwald Professor of Business  
Marketing Division  
Columbia Business School  
Columbia University  
[vgm2113@columbia.edu](mailto:vgm2113@columbia.edu)

Professor Eric J. Johnson  
Norman Eig Professor of Business  
Marketing Division  
Columbia Business School  
Columbia University  
[ejj3@gsb.columbia.edu](mailto:ejj3@gsb.columbia.edu)

Professor Joe J. Gladstone  
Assistant Professor of Behavioral Sciences and  
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Marketing Division  
Rady School of Management  
University of California, San Diego  
[jgladstone@ucsd.edu](mailto:jgladstone@ucsd.edu)

Professor Andrey Simonov  
Gary Winnick and Martin Granoff Associate  
Professor of Business  
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Professor Bernd H. Schmitt  
Robert D. Calkins Professor of International  
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[bhs1@columbia.edu](mailto:bhs1@columbia.edu)

## DISSERTATION ABSTRACTS

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Topic: The Informal and the Formal Marketplace: Differences and Consequences

Chair: Vicki Morwitz

Committee: Eric Johnson, Andrey Simonov, Joe Gladstone

Essay 1: Posner, Nathaniel, and Vicki Morwitz, “Social Concerns and Financial Reasoning when Borrowing from Family,” revising for resubmission to *Journal of Consumer Research* (Job Market Paper).

Consumers who face financial hardship may want to borrow money from friends and family members. From a financial standpoint, such informal loans are often attractive: they tend to offer favorable terms relative to formal loans and are available to many consumers. However, mixing family and money can be socially risky, potentially straining close relationships. We find that, relative to formal borrowing, informal borrowing elicits negative self-conscious emotions such as guilt, shame, and embarrassment. These emotions serve an important social role, helping borrowers preserve valued relationships. At the same time, thoughts associated with these emotions dominate the borrower’s cognition, leading consumers to neglect the financial advantages of informal loans. Although these emotions inhibit borrowers from seeking informal loans, they may also serve an interpersonal function by increasing lenders’ willingness to provide support. Our findings reveal a fundamental tension in informal borrowing: the very psychological processes that help consumers maintain social relationships can interfere with the financial tradeoff thinking required to make economically advantageous financial decisions.

Essay 2: Posner, Nathaniel, and Vicki Morwitz, “The Marketization of Informal Help,” manuscript in preparation.

When faced with a problem they need to solve, consumers can either choose to seek help from their social network (seeking informal help) or use the marketplace to solve their problem (purchasing formal help). I examine the impact of the availability of formal help on how consumers think about and seek informal help. First, we combine data from the American Time Use Survey with data on the staggered rollout of Uber and use a differences-in-differences design to document that the spread of ridesharing led to a decline in time spent providing informal aid across the United States. Next, I explore the psychology of interpersonal help seeking in the presence and absence of market-provided alternatives such as these. In a series of experiments, I find that, when considering market and social help-seeking options jointly (instead of considering only social help-seeking options) consumers’ desire to seek informal help diminishes, even when controlling for their preference for the market-provided alternative. Three sets of results converge to show that the market option’s presence changes how consumers approach seeking help: first, consumers believe that those they ask for help will view them more negatively if they seek help when market-provided alternatives are available (versus when they are absent). Second, they weigh possible costs to the person they are asking for help from more heavily in their decision process. Third, they worry more about being perceived to take advantage of the person they ask for help. These results suggest that the presence of a market option increases other-regarding preferences, forcing consumers to think carefully before approaching a close other for informal aid.



## SELECTED ABSTRACTS

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Posner, Nathaniel, Andrey Simonov, Kellen Mrkva, and Eric J. Johnson (2023), “Dark Defaults: How Choice Architecture Steers Political Campaign Donations,” *Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences*.

In the months before the 2020 U.S. election, several political campaign websites added prechecked boxes (defaults), automatically making all donations into recurring weekly contributions unless donors unchecked them. Since these changes occurred at different times for different campaigns, we use a staggered difference-in-differences design to measure the causal effects of defaults on donors’ behavior. We estimate that defaults increased campaign donations by over \$43 million while increasing requested refunds by almost \$3 million. The weekly default only impacted weekly recurring donations, and not other donations, suggesting that donors may not have intended to make weekly donations. The longer defaults were displayed, the more money campaigns raised through weekly donations. Donors did not compensate by changing the amount they donated. We found that the default had a larger impact on smaller donors and on donors who had no prior experience with defaults, causing them to start more chains and donate a larger proportion of their money through weekly recurring donations.

Posner, Nathaniel, and Joe Gladstone, “Beyond Exponential Growth Bias: Principal Linearity Neglect in Savings Judgments,” under second-round review at *Journal of Consumer Psychology*.

Estimating the future value of an asset requires combining three components: principal, interest rate, and duration. Extensive research documents how people underestimate exponential growth as duration increases (exponential growth bias). We identify a complementary error: people also underestimate the linear relationship between principal and future value. We term this misperception principal linearity neglect (PLN). Across four preregistered experiments where participants estimated final values of hypothetical retirement savings accounts ( $N = 3,876$ , Nobs = 20,370), participants underweighted the principal’s contribution to the final value by approximately 10%. This bias operated independently of exponential growth bias. Three converging findings are consistent with compressed magnitude representation as a plausible mechanism. First, PLN was attenuated less than exponential growth bias by financial literacy, numeracy, and decision time. Second, principal-future value relationships followed a power law consistent with Stevens’s (1957) psychophysical scaling. Finally, flexible functional forms improved model fit for exponential growth bias but not PLN. These findings suggest that errors in compound interest estimation arise from perceptual compression of numerical magnitudes - not just from errors in computation.

Posner, Nathaniel, Eric S. Park, and Bernd Schmitt, “Linguistic Variability, Mind Perception, and Trust in Artificial Intelligence,” revising for second-round review at *Journal of Marketing*.

Conversational AI chatbots powered by Generative AI (GenAI) can interact with and aid consumers in many situations such as customer service, shopping, and even therapy. In such situations, the extent to which the consumer trusts the chatbot is key to adoption and smooth interaction. But what chatbot behavior causes consumers to trust them? The authors propose that, over and above the ability of the GenAI chatbots to respond accurately to user messages, the extent to which the chatbots vary the phrasing of their outputs, termed linguistic variability, causes consumers to trust them more. Six studies (five main studies and a case study of ChatGPT), show that this variability affects trust because consumers see variability as a cue of agency - the ability to engage in goal-directed planning, reasoning, and thought. In addition, the

studies find preliminary evidence that agency perceptions lead to other downstream consequences such as willingness to pay and the perception that the AI is more empathetic. Finally, the case study shows that increasing variability by changing the AI's temperature can decrease the factual accuracy of their outputs, highlighting a potential variability-veracity tradeoff; chatbots' variability may, in some cases, come at the cost of their factual accuracy.

Reeck, Crystal, Nathaniel Posner, Kellen Mrkva, and Eric J. Johnson (2023), "Nudging App Adoption: Choice Architecture Facilitates Consumer Uptake of Mobile Apps," *Journal of Marketing*.

How can firms encourage consumers to adopt smartphone apps? The authors show that several inexpensive choice architecture techniques can make users more likely to enable important app features and complete app onboarding. Across six pre-registered experiments ( $n=5,968$ ) and a field experiment ( $n=594,997$ ), choice architecture interventions manipulating choice sequence, color, and wording of app adoption decisions dramatically increased app adoption. Across experiments, integrating multiple feature decisions into a single choice increased adoption. This integration effect emerges because it decreases decision noise and reduces the prominence of individual features, consistent with support theory. Changing colors to match habitual patterns commonly found in current digital interfaces appears to increase adoption by accelerating consumers' decisions. Finally, wording options as if enabling the app was the default response (even without changing the actual default) also increases adoption. These defaultless defaults may be particularly relevant in heavily regulated consumer domains, such as finance or healthcare. The effects generalized across different types of apps and were robust across subsamples varying in demographics, attitudes towards the apps, and political affiliation. These results suggest simple tools that marketing managers and app developers can use to increase app adoption.

Mrkva, Kellen, Nathaniel Posner, Crystal Reeck, and Eric J. Johnson (2023), "Do nudges reduce disparities? Choice architecture compensates for low consumer knowledge," *Journal of Marketing*.

Choice architecture tools, commonly known as nudges, powerfully impact decisions and can improve welfare. Yet it is unclear *who* is most impacted by nudges. If nudge effects are moderated by socioeconomic status (SES), these differential effects could increase or decrease disparities across consumers. Using field data and several preregistered studies, the authors demonstrate that consumers with lower SES, domain knowledge, and numerical ability are impacted more by a wide variety of nudges. As a result, "good nudges" designed to increase selection of superior options reduced choice disparities, improving choices more among consumers with lower SES, lower financial literacy, and lower numeracy than among those with higher levels of these variables. Compared with "good nudges," "bad nudges" designed to facilitate selection of inferior options exacerbated choice disparities. These results generalized across real retirement decisions, different nudges, and different decision domains. Across studies, the authors tested different explanations of why SES, domain knowledge, and numeracy moderate nudges. The results suggest that nudges are a useful tool for those who wish to reduce disparities. The research concludes with a discussion of implications for marketing firms and segmentation.

Posner, Nathaniel, Shai Davidai, and Vicki Morwitz, “Misperceptions of Indebtedness Promote Prosociality,” working paper.

Interpersonal interactions involving prosocial support, such as paying for others’ expenses or doing favors, often evoke feelings of indebtedness in beneficiaries. Do people who provide such benefits realize that their beneficiaries might feel indebted to them? Across ten studies, we find that benefactors systematically underestimate beneficiaries’ feelings of indebtedness. We show that this misperception stems from how prosocial exchange can alter peer relationships. Drawing on relational models theory, we demonstrate that providing a benefit can introduce a hierarchical, authority ranking dynamic to a relationship. When both parties desire peer relationships, beneficiaries focus on repayment to restore relational equality, whereas benefactors attend less to repayment to avoid highlighting the hierarchy. This divergence, combined with egocentric projection, leads benefactors to underestimate beneficiaries’ indebtedness. Consistent with this account, the misperception attenuates in relationships with a preexisting hierarchy and when uninvolved observers predict beneficiaries’ feelings. Finally, we show that correcting benefactors’ misperceptions reduces their willingness to help. We conclude by discussing implications for interpersonal relationships and organizations.

Posner, Nathaniel, Elizabeth Friedman, and Jason Dana, “Silent Sanctions: Costly Private Welfare Destruction in Response to Innocuous Yet Repugnant Consumption Behaviors,” manuscript in preparation.

The modern market economy enables large-scale communication among anonymous individuals, allowing consumers to observe each other’s attitudes and behaviors at scale. We argue this gives rise to a pervasive and underappreciated set of marketplace costs. We introduce the term silent sanctions to describe where one pays a personal cost to make a target worse off when the act sends no signal to the target or to outside observers. Silent sanctions differ from classic punishment in that they carry none of the social benefits of enforcing norms and cooperation or signaling one’s own positive traits. Further, silent sanctions often occur in response to actions that cause no harm, such as private consumption behaviors (e.g., watching an offensive movie) or privately held opinions (e.g., believing drugs should be legalized). Ten studies demonstrate that consumers sacrifice their own money or convenience to make other consumers, firms, or charities worse off when they disapprove of the target’s opinions or behaviors, even when the target will never learn of their decision. Silent sanctions occur because consumers feel morally obligated to withhold benefits from actors they have judged to be of bad character, a process independent from anger and moral outrage. These results shed light on an important and hidden cost facing the marketplace, which decreases the material welfare of both the sanctioner and target while producing no social benefit.